

MEMORANDUM

TO: Maritime Compliance Review

FROM: Abdul Hadi

DATE: June 2026

RE: Sanctions Screening Audit: Port of Los Angeles/Long Beach AIS Traffic, 2023–2025

Finding

A full sanctions screen of AIS vessel traffic at the Port of Los Angeles/Long Beach returned zero confirmed matches against the 2026 OpenSanctions Consolidated List. Across 21 million tracked movements between 2023 and 2025, no vessel, registered owner, or affiliated legal entity was found to appear on active OFAC, EU, or UN sanctions designations.

Scope and Methodology

The audit drew on two sources: the LA/LB AIS dataset (2023-2025, approximately 21 million records) and the OpenSanctions Consolidated List (2026), which aggregates over 70,000 sanctioned entities across OFAC, the EU, the UN, and country specific frameworks such as the Japan METI End User List, UK FCDO Sanctions List and Australian Sanctions Consolidated List, among others. Screening was conducted via a multi-condition SQL join matching on vessel MMSI, IMO number, registered name, and known aliases. The join logic extended beyond hull-level screening to parent companies, beneficial owners, and affiliated legal entities, enabling detection of shadow ownership structures where the vessel itself may not be directly designated.

Technical Validation

To confirm that zero matches reflected the dataset rather than a pipeline failure, a synthetic control test was performed. A known AIS identifier was manually injected into the sanctions lookup table; the system flagged it immediately, confirming the join logic and indexing were functioning correctly. Query performance across the 21 million row dataset was achieved through B-Tree indexing on MMSI and IMO columns, reducing execution time from an indefinite or failed state to completion within minutes.

Methodological Caveats

These findings are bounded by the visibility of AIS data itself. Dark activity including transponder disabling and AIS signal spoofing represents a known limitation of any AIS based compliance screen, and vessels engaged in deliberate evasion would not appear in this dataset regardless of sanctions status. A temporal gap also exists between the 2025 AIS traffic ceiling and the 2026 sanctions list; entities designated after their last recorded port call would not be captured. This audit should be read as a screen of visible, cooperative traffic rather than a comprehensive compliance certification.